

PRELUDE IX

THERE exists no more delicate study in pianoforte touch than the first four bars of the right hand of this Prelude. It would be easy enough to ensure that the tied notes were still clearly singing at the moment of suspension, but for the fact that they have immediately to be struck again. The unfortunate player lifts his finger for the purpose; the note vanishes, and nothing will persuade the ear that the sense of the phrase is more than the following single melody:



Now, though this melody is really part of the meaning (and is not the only case in this Prelude where two parts make a collective melody besides their own individual sense), it asserts itself quite clearly enough on the pianoforte when the whole attention of the player is directed to keeping the parts separate. Accordingly, it is extremely important to master the problem of the tied notes. The fingering given in the present edition enables the player to catch the repeated notes without losing the ties. The lower part should not be brought out at all, but should be far fainter than the upper. It cannot fail to be heard, as it moves while the upper stands. Moreover, the rule for the pianoforte playing of close imitations with crossing or colliding parts is always to bring out the leader and not the answer. The ear must first know what is led; it will then easily recognise the answer as an echo. If both are put on a level, mere mutual interruption is the result.

When these four bars are mastered, the rest is simple. The quality of tone has already settled itself in this opening, and the player will not be satisfied with any that lacks *cantabile* in the quietest levels, or threatens hardness in the climaxes. *Legato* is indicated throughout, except perhaps in the bass of the second theme, bars 18-20. This may be either a not dry *staccato*, or slurred in pairs like the bass (so marked by Bach himself) of the cradle-song in the Christmas Oratorio. Nor is it against such slurring that it is less suitable to the right-hand development of the figure in bars 21-22 and 43-44; uniformity is of no great importance where the expression so evidently changes in any case. In bars 32-34 be sure that the parts do not fail to enter as a dialogue instead of coalescing.

It is impossible to dispense with the consideration of the alternative readings given in bar 50. The main text there is according to the British Museum autograph. It means that the bass enters as a new part; not as the same part that gave bar 49, for that part (according to every possible construing) runs up into the right hand to the crotchet E in bar 50. The other reading, attested by very good MSS., and possibly the final decision, means that the whole flow of semi-quavers from bar 49 to the second crotchet of bar 50 is one phrase, and that even the rest of the bar is attracted into it while still retaining the character of dialogue. This is undoubtedly the stronger reading. But the autograph reading, being unknown as such to Bischoff, and inaccessible elsewhere in print than in the appendix of Vol. XLV. of the *Bach-Gesellschaft*, seems too important to put merely into a footnote, especially as it is written over an erasure which might have been the other reading. (There are, however, two further variants known.)

The *tempo* is a flowing six or slow three. The slow movement of Beethoven's F major Violin Sonata gives a good familiar idea of the necessary breadth and flow.

In bar 43 the first note of the left hand stands as an *appoggiatura* in the MSS. As the passage is exactly parallel to bar 21 it is here written accordingly. The mordent in bar 40 has been written out as grace-notes (to be played on the beat), as it otherwise is difficult to make legible in the middle of the chord.

FUGUE IX

WITH the exception of two outlying bass-notes this whole Fugue is singable by an unaccompanied four-part chorus or vocal quartet, and has, in fact, been so sung with exquisite effect, being actually easier for voices than almost any of Bach's vocal works. The high entry of the soprano in bars 37-38 has the exact meaning of vocal high notes—*i.e.*, it constitutes a climax

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in virtue simply of being a rise to the top of the voice. The player need aim at nothing but vocal effect, both in melody and harmony. He need not undergo contortions in order to secure a mechanically theoretical *legato* without pedal; even a chorus has consonants as well as vowels. But there must be no percussion and no forcing of tone; and at the end the player, instead of quoting "Rule, Britannia," should attend to those crotchet rests in the inner parts, the *suspirium* or "sigh" of the sixteenth-century choral writers.

In the Exposition (bars 1-7) the counterpoint to the Answer (particularly bar 3) is maintained so as to form a conventional but recognisable Countersubject (see bars 4½-5 and 6), which is also used to form the cadence in the dominant in bars 8-9. Then the First Stretto occurs (bars 9-12), in which the Subject enters in all four voices at half a bar and one bar, etc.—viz., alto and tenor in the lower fifth at half a bar, and, when the tenor has proceeded for one bar, conversely in bass and soprano in the upper fourth at half a bar. Then follows the only Episode in the Fugue, beyond the occasional bar-and-a-half formation of a full close. The four voices take up a figure closely resembling that of the Countersubject (which is, indeed, alluded to during the Stretto itself) and develop it in four-part canon (do not confine your singing tone to the crotchets) from bar 11½ to the close at bar 15-16. (The order is soprano, alto, bass, tenor, and a final allusion in the alto, all at half-bar's distance.) Now comes the Second or Chromatic Stretto, a very important contrapuntal type, apt to remain unrecognised (like other typical events) in this Fugue by reason of the extreme terseness of the whole. In this the Subject is combined with two new Countersubjects full of chromatic steps, and forming a Triple Counterpoint. There is room for only three occurrences of these new Countersubjects, and, owing to the Stretto, they meet the Subject at a different point the second time; but they establish themselves with complete regularity and accuracy (bars 16-17, tenor and bass; 17½-18, alto and tenor; 19-20, soprano and alto). From failure to recognise this, Kroll and Bischoff reject the necessary E♯ in bar 19, which is well attested by the MSS. of pupils; the only objection to it being a scruple as to the remainder of E♯ in the tenor, the very last kind of "false relation" Bach would mind.

After this harmonically rich Stretto a formal close is made in F♯ minor, and now comes the Third or Variation Stretto, another type systematically developed by Bach, Beethoven, Schumann, and Brahms, but recognised by few, if any, theorists. In this the Subject is altered by filling out its intervals and syncopating part of its rhythm. The Stretto is at a minim's distance, first between soprano and alto in the lower fourth (bars 23-24), then, conversely, between bass and tenor in the upper fifth (bars 25-26). As the Answer acquires a peculiar character through reversing the accents, and as the interval between the parts is too wide to cause confusion, both members of the pairs should be clearly and expressively brought out.

Immediately upon this follows the Fourth or Diminished Stretto, in which the four parts enter (as usual, in pairs) between the end of bar 26 and the end of bar 29. In the middle of bar 30, while the bass is giving the Diminished Subject once more, the alto enters in the tonic with the original Subject. There is now no Stretto (compare Fugue VII. of this Book, and other instances where Bach interpolates a plain entry of the Subject between a long development of complexities or episodes and the final Stretto); but the tenor and soprano accompany with a dialogue which cannot fail to suggest an inversion of the Diminished Subject, though the first interval is unrecognisably disguised as a very expressive descending fifth. In bars 32-33 the player must show the crossing of parts; this is best done by letting all the four soprano minims (and the F♯ crotchet to which they go) sing out while the alto is subdued. After a close in G♯ minor the fifth and last Stretto appears (bar 35). This is really a recapitulation of the First Stretto, with its last entry put, by way of climax, into a higher octave, and with the addition of wonderful counterpoint in crotchets which, beginning by suggesting an inversion of the Diminished Subject, drift into an unmistakable resumption of the conventional Countersubject of the Exposition. There is little doubt that the two notes marked with an asterisk would have been written an octave higher by Bach if such stretches had been safe on an instrument with no damper-pedal. We should then have an unmistakable entry of the Inverted Diminution, besides the best distribution of the harmony. There is no harm in adopting this. In bar 40 the bass makes a final entry, prolonging the Subject in a descending scale followed by the soprano to the close.

The *tempo* is, of course, a quite slow four minims in the bar, or a flowing eight.